

Chapter 153_1 - Curtain Fall

Chu Qingqiu didn't even feel the pain. She was wrapped by black mist around her limbs, slowly sitting down, her pupils reflecting Ning Fuyi's silhouette.

Her long hair merged with the black smoke, the smoke like a hunting robe, spreading in the wind, with a silver ring around her waist and hidden powers within her sleeves.

It was the exact same attire as her previous life, making it feel like being in a different world for a moment, yet not completely the same, because the pink light on the right side was even more dazzling than sunset clouds, as if she had shattered the boundary between day and night, presenting an eerie harmony.

"Such powerful demonic energy!" At this moment, the various immortals standing beneath the Mountain-River Diagram¹ exclaimed in amazement, straining to support the diagram with every vein bulging on their foreheads.

Earlier, Chu Qingqiu had let go, but fortunately a black-clothed woman had appeared from nowhere with formidable magical power, allowing them to hold on for a few more hours.

The black-clothed woman was veiled, her curled hair falling down, her entire body wrapped in brown hemp cloth, making it impossible to discern her figure.

"Such demonic energy could probably only be matched by the Demon Lord from ten thousand years ago! Ning Fuyi truly is a demon!" The Ghost-Sight Sect Master was already bent over by the Mountain-River Diagram's pressure, gasping as he spoke.

"Whether she's a demon or not doesn't matter anymore. We can only hope she can deal with Tianrui and prevent the six realms from returning to chaos." Tang Wenshu was covered in sweat, forcibly channeling his power again to resist the force overflowing from the Mountain-River Diagram.

Li Hanlin's hands had gone soft. She lowered her head, gritting her teeth and crying out: "I can barely hold on anymore!"

The words and cries of those around her sounded a hundred times clearer in Ning Fuyi's ears. This feeling of controlling the universe was familiar yet strange - if she closed her eyes, she could almost hear the sound of the great river flowing beneath her feet.

Unfamiliar, but extremely powerful.

The Xiangsi² sword hummed excitedly in her hand, almost too difficult to grip. She could actually understand the thoughts of a sword - from the burning hilt to the trembling blade, everything was clamoring: "Long time no see."

If only those with murderous intent could control the Emei needle, then only those who felt boundless love could awaken the Xiangsi divine sword.

Xiangsi had been revived twice, both times because someone had risked their life to stand in front of her.

Xiangsi suddenly trembled heavily. Ning Fuyi hurriedly looked down and saw that Baili Shiqi's body, which had fallen there earlier, had vanished without a trace.

In its place was a red agate-like blood pearl that grew larger and larger, rising with holy light.

"Shiqi..." Ning Fuyi murmured. She tried to catch the blood pearl with her hand, but it avoided her touch and continued to slowly rise toward the rolling dark clouds overhead.

A young girl's voice rang in her ears, clear and ethereal. It was a wordless song whose melody made all who heard it red-eyed. Everyone's gaze followed the blood pearl as it soared upward, drilling into the gloomy sea of clouds.

Moisture slid from the corner of Ning Fuyi's eyes. She bit her teeth and raised the Emei needle. Several thunderbolts pierced through the clouds, thunder clouds gathered, and fine rain turned into a downpour.

Or perhaps it wasn't rain, but the tears of Penglai³ Saint. The teardrops fell on the battlefield outside Penglai, where piles of corpses lay quietly in the rain. The immortal soldiers and generals who were still fighting slowly stopped, staring blankly at their blood-stained hands.

Battles between immortals were far more brutal than those in the mortal world. The sea of clouds was covered with corpses stretching very far - immortals and demons alike. Most of the bodies had already been burned by fire, still crackling and popping.

These fierce flames burned into rosy clouds, decorating the spaces between cloud layers.

The sounds of killing outside gradually diminished. Ning Fuyi turned around. A mocking laugh came from in front of her. Looking up, she saw Tianrui had somehow risen on clouds at some point, standing before her with hands behind his back, his eyes still holding lingering surprise that hadn't faded.

He didn't care about the outside world, only surprised that she could control demonic energy while preserving half of her immortal body for herself.

But soon he smiled and spoke: "You see, I told you - you and I share the same root. We should be on the same path."

With demonic energy released, Ning Fuyi could no longer be influenced by him. Without saying half a word more, she raised her sword to strike at him. However, Tianrui's body immediately became a phantom, and when he spoke again, he was already standing on another side.

"Young one, your demonic root was born from my heart. Do you think with just half your demonic energy, you can kill me?" Tianrui's hoarse voice let out a cackling laugh, shaking his head pitifully.

"Why did you leave the demonic root in my body?" Though Ning Fuyi already had the answer in her heart, she still asked with hands behind her back.

While speaking, her left hand bent slightly behind her waist, forming character symbols one by one. This was sign language learned in the mortal world - she believed Chu Qingqiu could see it.

"I said it earlier - my other weapon is you." Emperor Tianrui didn't notice her hand gestures and said softly, "The places the Mountain-River Diagram cannot destroy, you can."

"You're the same as the evil spirits - naturally born demon seed."

"Oh." Ning Fuyi laughed. So in her previous life, she had indeed unknowingly served as someone else's bride⁴. Fortunately, Chu Qingqiu had activated the Reincarnation Array, giving them another chance.

She struck out with her sword again. The cold sword light illuminated the cloud layer. This time Tianrui didn't dodge but casually waved his hand to dispel that light, then softly chanted something. Ning Fuyi's ears suddenly went quiet.

A red-clothed figure burst through the rubble and debris, flying out. Along with the woman's piercing scream, a bloody tint suddenly flashed through Ning Fuyi's eyes. She instinctively rushed forward but couldn't stop the silver needles aimed at the woman. Several needles pierced through her body, and she burst into blood flowers in mid-air.

"Jiuying⁵!" Ning Fuyi never thought she could make such an ear-piercing shout. She only managed to extend her arms in time to catch the woman in her embrace.

Blood mixed with rainwater made the red clothes even redder. Jiuying's eyes still held confusion and surprise. Her golden pupils turned to the corner of her eyes, her mouth opening as if wanting to say something, but she quickly lost her breath.

Her hand was still clutching Ning Fuyi's clothing. Finally, her body scattered into red light, leaving only a crimson claw print on the sleeve.

Ning Fuyi watched helplessly as the red light dimmed. This moment was even more heart-wrenching than before. She furiously swung her sword toward Tianrui, but as soon as she raised her head, her entire body felt as if it had fallen into an ice cellar, cold from foot to hair.

"No, don't..." Ning Fuyi seemed frozen. Tianrui's hand somehow gripped Chu Qingqiu's neck. Chu Qingqiu was seriously injured and couldn't break free, only able to tilt her head back in pain.

Before Ning Fuyi could move even slightly, the woman's jade-white neck was quickly cut through by a blood mark deep enough to see bone. Her white clothes visibly turned red, fluttering down from Tianrui's palm.

In that moment, Ning Fuyi's mind suddenly went completely blank. She stood dumbly in the distance, even forgetting to rush forward, just watching those white clothes fall like a broken white flower.

Hot liquid suddenly surged from her lips, then from her chest. Looking down, Ning Fuyi realized she had vomited blood. Her knees went soft as she knelt on the ground, no longer able to hold the sword steady in her hand.

Tianrui's maniacal laughter echoed around her ears. Ning Fuyi didn't wail or cry; she just crouched down, staring fixedly at her own blood seeping into the black clothes, gradually tainted with black energy.

It was as if everything had disappeared, including herself. This feeling lasted for a long time.

The bracelet on her wrist suddenly made a crisp sound, like plucking a zither string. Ning Fuyi's body didn't move, but her eyelashes suddenly opened.

Shiqi's words rose from the bottom of her heart: "Remember, truth and falsehood - what the eyes see may be illusion."

Tianrui had stood in front of her for quite a while without making a move against her, which at least proved he didn't want to kill her, or rather, he simply couldn't kill her!

Everything he did was only to make her fall into demonhood.

The demonic root was part of the evil spirit. Her body had nurtured the demonic root, while Tianrui was merely possessed, not the evil spirit's own body, and couldn't necessarily bear all of the evil spirit's demonic power.

So what Tianrui said was true - she was the evil spirit.

Only when she completely became a demon would the evil spirit truly be revived.

"Chu Qingqiu, are you ready?" Ning Fuyi suddenly said, and the bracelet rang once more.

So Ning Fuyi exhaled and picked up Xiangsi again.

"Let's begin," she said.

Thus, in everyone's line of sight, Ning Fuyi, who had been wrapped in thick fog and occasionally letting out painful howls, suddenly raised her hand to cleave through the fog. Then, under Tianrui's suddenly changing expression, a blinding white formation rose from beneath her feet, and a gardenia flower that had almost solidified bloomed from within the formation.

"Familiar? The thing that once killed you - you still can't escape it now." Ning Fuyi revealed a cunning smile with her mouth full of fresh blood.

"No, you..." Tianrui's eyes finally surged with terror. He channeled his power to resist, but it was already too late.

"Waning Moon Formation!" With Ning Fuyi's fierce shout, Chu Qingqiu had already leaped to her side. The two stood at the eye of the formation as black, white, and pink⁶ lights streaked across the sky.

The aura blocked everyone's sight. People could only squint their eyes and see through the gaps in their eyelashes that gardenia flower, no longer pure white, pressing down overwhelmingly toward Tianrui's body.

Thus, amid hoarse roars of fury, Emperor Tianrui's body was cut apart petal by petal. Black energy poured from his shattered torso like maggots, scurrying wildly, but ultimately couldn't escape being slashed in two by the Xiangsi that Ning Fuyi threw with a flourish.

"So what if you kill me? The world will still be destroyed! Hahahaha..."

Finally, amid maniacal laughter, he scattered into a foul stench that was mercilessly swept away by the wind.

The radiance of the Waning Moon Formation dissipated. Chu Qingqiu, already exhausted, collapsed again. Ning Fuyi caught her around the waist, holding her tightly in her arms as they landed on the ground.

"Chu Qingqiu, we did it. It's dead..." Ning Fuyi's hand trembled as she reached toward Chu Qingqiu's pulse, wanting to test how seriously she was injured.

"I know. I saw it." Chu Qingqiu let her touch, her hand softly brushing across Ning Fuyi's lips, trying to wipe away the blood. "Quite clever."

"I'm the cleverest." Ning Fuyi sniffled and grasped her hand.

Several exhausted gasps came from above. Only then did the two remember the Mountain-River Diagram. They hurriedly looked up to see that the people controlling the diagram had already collapsed from exhaustion, spitting blood and falling one after another.

Li Hanlin was the first to drop. Tang Wenshu directly fainted, while Black Scales⁷, who held on until the end, had blood flowing from all seven orifices⁸ but still desperately supported it.

The Mountain-River Diagram was already covered with golden light - wherever it glowed, there were cracks.

The earth, extremely far from the half-sky, was already transmitting rumbling sounds. Without releasing her divine consciousness, Ning Fuyi could hear the rivers roaring and mountains weeping.

Footnotes:

¹ **Mountain-River Diagram (山河图)** - A powerful magical artifact that contains or represents the landscape and geography of the realm.

² **Xiangsi (相思)** - Literally means "mutual longing" or "lovesickness." It's the name of Ning Fuyi's divine sword.

³ **Penglai (蓬莱境)** - A mystical realm in Chinese mythology, often associated with immortals.

⁴ **Made someone else's bride (为旁人做了嫁衣)** - A Chinese idiom meaning to work for someone else's benefit without gaining anything oneself.

⁵ **Jiuying (九婴)** - A nine-headed mythical beast/character in the story.

⁶ **Three lights** - The formation creates three colored lights representing different energies.

⁷ **Black Scales (黑鳞)** - A character name, likely referring to a person with scale-like characteristics.

⁸ **Seven orifices (七窍)** - In traditional Chinese medicine, refers to the seven openings of the head: two eyes, two nostrils, two ears, and the mouth.